Honecker's incapacitation led to the longest period of official silence in his political career. He appointed Günter Mittag as his temporary replacement during his absence. Normally, that job went to Krenz but Honecker was wary of his deputy's loyalty so Krenz was side-lined and instructed to take a long vacation (a move which left him seething).

In hospital, Honecker was supposedly oblivious to the strengthening of grassroots opposition movements spurred by events across the Eastern bloc. 'He was cut off from the world,' Bernd Bruckner recalled. 'He couldn't watch TV, read newspapers or his mail. So, he was in a space where no information could get to him – he needed to recover.'14

To make matters worse, his appointed deputy, Günter Mittag – who was also ill – ummed and aahed when confronted with problems. (Mittag was severely diabetic and in 1984 one of his lower legs was amputated: the other was removed late in 1989.)

When asked about this period in 1991, Honecker snapped: 'I was on an operating table. I couldn't react perfectly.'15 As he remained bedridden, the pro-democracy lobby continued to grow at a hellish tempo. Compounding matters, thousands of GDR citizens continued to seek political asylum at West German embassies in Czechoslovakia, Poland and Hungary. By September, Hungary, which had begun dismantling border fortifications with Austria in early May – opened its frontier to the West, thus allowing East Germans to enter Austria and journey unhindered to West Germany. 'When the thing became known to me – I was still in the intensive care unit,' Honecker recounted. 'I phoned up and said: "Now listen here, have you actually made contact with the Hungarians so that they would respect their commitments?" I was told that something would be done.' 16 Nothing happened. Paralyzed from the outset by their leader's illness, the entire SED Politburo sat silent, shocked by the swiftness and gravity of events. As Krenz later acknowledged, the 'system' was tailored to Honecker calling the shots and nobody in the Politburo took any initiatives. Finally, Gerhard Schürer harried Krenz to act against Honecker during a secret meeting in early September. Unsurprisingly, support came from the sly old Prime Minister Willi Stoph and Stasi boss Erich Mielke, and the heads of the SED district leadership of Berlin and Karl-Marx-Stadt, Günter Schabowski and